

The Entrepreneur Within You

Empower Lab (Empower 40K) – Educational Module

Module 1: Entrepreneurship Is Already Around You

Welcome to Empower Lab, your learning space to explore entrepreneurship in a practical, confident, and community-centered way.

This module is made for young entrepreneurs across Africa. You'll explore what entrepreneurship really means, who entrepreneurs are, and how to start building strong entrepreneurial habits, using your everyday life as your starting point.

How to use this module

Go one section at a time. Take a pause when you reach the reflection prompt. If you're learning with others, talk through the questions together and share examples from your community.

Before You Begin

Take a moment to set yourself up to learn with focus and curiosity.

- ☐ Use your community, home, school, neighborhood, or market—as your classroom.
- ☐ Come with one example of a business you admire, and be ready to explain why.

Quick warm-up

Write down 3 businesses you see or use often (for example: food sellers, mobile money agents, transport services, salons, tailors, farmers, repair shops).

Entrepreneurship Is Already Around You

Entrepreneurship isn't only something that happens in big offices or online. It's happening every day—around your street, in local markets, in small shops, and wherever people find smart ways to help others.

Any time someone notices a need and responds with a product, service, or solution, that's entrepreneurship in action.

What you notice	What need it solves	How it creates value
A water vendor	Access to clean water	Saves time and improves convenience
A phone repairer	Broken devices	Restores tools people rely on for work and communication
A food seller	Affordable meals	Feeds people quickly and consistently

Discussion prompt: What's one example of entrepreneurship you see often—and what problem is it solving?

Learning Outcomes

By the end of Module 1, you should be able to:

- Explain entrepreneurship in simple, everyday language.
 - Describe who entrepreneurs are and what they actually do.
 - Question the idea that you need a lot of money before you can begin.
 - Spot common places business ideas come from in daily life.
 - Practice your first entrepreneurial habit: noticing problems and opportunities around you.
-

So, What Is Entrepreneurship?

Entrepreneurship is what happens when you notice a problem (or an opportunity) and you take action to create value—often by offering something useful that people are willing to pay for or support.

Yes, money matters. But entrepreneurship is also about solving real problems, improving everyday life, and building something helpful for others.

Key idea
Entrepreneurship = noticing needs + creating solutions + taking consistent action.

Who Is an Entrepreneur?

An entrepreneur is someone who chooses to solve problems by creating value—through a business, a service, a product, or even a better way of doing something.

Entrepreneurs can be young or old. They can start small. They can work alone or with a team. What matters isn't the size of the business—it's the decision to start, keep learning, and keep improving as you go.

Entrepreneurial mindset	What it looks like
Responsibility	Owning results and learning from mistakes
Creativity	Thinking of new solutions with available resources
Courage	Starting even when you don't have all the answers
Consistency	Showing up repeatedly, improving step by step

Do You Need Money to Start?

Many people think you need a lot of money before you can start a business. Money can help, but it's not the only way to begin.

You can start with what you already have: your skills, your time, the people you know, your understanding of your community, and your willingness to learn.

Reality check

If you wait for the “perfect time,” you might never start. Begin small, learn fast, and grow through experience.

Small-start examples:

- Offer a simple service people already need (tutoring, laundry support, hair styling, basic repairs).
- Sell a small product with clear demand (snacks, airtime, stationery).
- Team up with someone who has a resource you don’t yet have (space, equipment, supply access).

Where Do Business Ideas Come From?

Great business ideas often start with simple attention. Many of the strongest ideas aren’t complicated—they grow from real needs people face every day.

Here are practical places to look for ideas:

- **Problems** — What frustrates people? What wastes time? What keeps going wrong?
- **Gaps** — What’s missing in your area? What do people travel far to find?
- **Improvement** — What works, but could be better, faster, cheaper, or more reliable?
- **Skills** — What can you do well that others often need help with?
- **Trends** — What are people starting to buy, use, or care about more?

Observation	Possible idea	Who benefits?
Students struggle to print assignments	Low-cost printing and stationery support	Students, teachers
People waste time in long queues	Queue support, delivery, or appointment coordination	Busy workers, parents
Local produce spoils quickly	Simple storage, drying, packaging, or resale system	Farmers, households

Your First Entrepreneurial Habit

Your first entrepreneurial habit is learning to observe. That means noticing problems, needs, patterns, and opportunities in everyday life.

This habit is powerful because it helps you generate ideas again and again—without waiting for someone else to hand you a “perfect” business idea.

Practice (10 minutes):

1. Look around your home, school, street, or market.
2. Write down 5 problems, frustrations, or “small hassles” you notice.
3. Next to each one, write one possible solution—even if it feels small.
4. Circle the solution that feels most realistic to test in the next 7 days.

Reflection prompt

Which problem do you feel most motivated to solve—and why? What is one small step you can take this week to learn more about it (ask questions, research prices, observe customers, test a simple version)?

A Thought to Carry With You

Entrepreneurship begins with paying attention—and believing that you can create value with what you have, where you are.

Start small. Stay curious. Learn fast. Keep going.